Mission Statement

Crossroads is committed to creating an inclusive space where individuals can explore, innovate, and grow. By providing access to advanced equipment, mentorship, and real-world opportunities, we empower people to pursue their passions and develop new skills. Our mission is to break down barriers to learning, nurture creativity, and inspire the next generation of thinkers, creators, and leaders.

Business Offering

Crossroads brings innovation to the community by establishing an open learning hub focused on STEM education. Crossroads aspires to be more than just a makerspace; it aims to become a hub of inspiration, learning, and innovation in Langford, BC, and beyond. By continuously evolving its offerings and fostering a vibrant, connected community, Crossroads will serve as a blueprint for how inclusive spaces can drive creativity, growth, and resilience.

Problem Statement

Langford, BC, one of Canada's fastest-growing communities, lacks a central space for community members to connect, be inspired, and create together. While the area is home to brilliant universities and colleges that teach essential skills, there are few places where individuals can apply these skills in practical, innovative, and exciting ways. Additionally, as the country faces a mental health and addictions crisis, there’s a critical need for spaces that foster connection, creativity, and purpose.

Solution

Crossroads addresses these challenges by creating a physical space where STEM education is accessible to all, with the only barrier being the willingness to participate. Drawing inspiration from Bruce Alexander's Rat Park experiment, Crossroads recognizes that an enriched, supportive environment can significantly improve well-being and engagement. By providing mentorship, cutting-edge resources, and opportunities for collaboration, Crossroads fosters innovation, combats isolation, and helps build a resilient, forward-thinking community.

The ideal customer persona for Crossroads

Curious Beginners: Individuals with little to no experience but a strong desire to learn how things work, create, and innovate.
Experienced Makers: Professionals or hobbyists who can use the space to work on their own projects while mentoring others.

Students and Educators: Learners looking to supplement formal education with hands-on experiences and educators seeking a space to engage students in practical STEM activities. Community Builders: Individuals seeking a welcoming, collaborative environment to connect socially and intellectually.

Existing Solutions in the Market

Victoria Makerspace (makerspace.ca) is a key competitor in the region, offering facilities such as a woodshop, cold metal shop, electronics workspace, and a hot metal shed. While it provides valuable resources for creative projects, it has notable limitations. Access is exclusive, requiring users to apply for membership, which creates a barrier for those seeking an open and inclusive environment. Its limited operating hours restrict usage opportunities, and its "club-like" atmosphere caters more to hobbyists and experts, which might discourage beginners or casual participants. Additionally, its resources focus on traditional maker activities and lack a broader emphasis on STEM education or innovation.

Some reviews of Victoria makers space : https://www.reddit.com/r/VictoriaBC/comments/1ekted0/victoria_makerspace/?rdt=47736

UVIC and Camosun college both have a space similar to this which is partly the inspiration for a community learning hub as such.

Opportunity for Crossroads

Crossroads seeks to surpass these limitations by offering a fully drop-in, beginner-friendly community center that welcomes everyone, regardless of experience. Unlike Victoria Makerspace, Crossroads will provide comprehensive STEM-focused resources, including robotics, 3D printing, coding, biology, chemistry, engineering, and more. Operating 24/7, it will provide unmatched flexibility for individuals to innovate and create on their own schedules. With an emphasis on hands-on learning, mentorship, and inclusivity, Crossroads will serve as a true community hub, fostering creativity, connection, and practical skill development. Inspired

by the Rat Park experiment, Crossroads will also prioritize mental health and well-being, offering a space that combats isolation and nurtures growth for people of all ages and backgrounds.

Marketing and Promotion

use to reach out to your target customers.
Social Media: Platforms like Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn to promote events, share success stories, and engage with the community.
Community Outreach: Flyers, posters, and word-of-mouth campaigns in local schools, libraries, and businesses.
Workshops and Events: Hosting free introductory workshops to showcase what Crossroads offers.
Local Media: Collaborating with newspapers, radio stations, and online blogs to spread awareness.
Partnerships: Teaming up with local schools, universities, and community organizations to promote Crossroads.

Business Model

Start-up Costs: The initial expenses for Crossroads will be substantial. Excluding the costs associated with securing and maintaining the physical space, the cost to launch could range from $500,000 to $5,000,000, depending on the scale of the operation. A detailed cost spreadsheet is being developed to better estimate these expenses.

Revenue Streams:
Corporate Training: Crossroads will partner with local companies and educational institutions to offer corporate training programs in STEM fields, leadership, and innovation. These programs could be structured as team-building exercises or professional development courses.

Event Hosting:
Maker Fairs & Expos: Host annual or bi-annual events where community members, makers, and businesses can showcase their products and ideas. Revenue will be generated through entry fees and booth rentals.

Hackathons & Competitions: Organize paid hackathons, robotics competitions, and creative challenges. These events will attract sponsorships and registration fees while fostering innovation and publicity.

Retail and Merchandising
Maker Shop: A retail section will be established where members can sell their creations, with a small commission going to Crossroads. Additionally, essential materials like 3D printer filaments, electronics kits, and DIY kits will be stocked, attracting walk-in customers and generating revenue.

Merchandising: Branded merchandise (e.g., t-shirts, mugs, or stickers) will be sold to promote the brand and generate extra income.
Corporate Sponsorships: Crossroads will partner with local businesses or large corporations in the tech, engineering, and education sectors. In exchange for financial support or equipment donations, businesses will receive advertising opportunities or be featured in community events.

Grant Funding: Crossroads will explore Canadian government grants and philanthropic funding options targeted at educational initiatives, mental health, and STEM-focused organizations. This funding will help support both start-up and ongoing operational expenses.

Enhancing Community Engagement and Retention

Mentorship and Volunteer Programs
Mentorship Program: Create a structured mentorship program where experienced makers, educators, or professionals volunteer to help beginners. This will add value to the community and encourage more participation.
Student Internships & Volunteer Opportunities: Build partnerships with local universities and colleges, offering internship programs that give students real-world experience in running a community hub, teaching STEM subjects, or learning about new technologies.

Loyalty Rewards: Implement a loyalty program where members earn points for attending workshops, using equipment, or engaging in community events. These points could be redeemed for discounts on membership, workshops, or retail items.

Technology Integration and Automation
Digital Membership Platform
App or Website: Develop a digital platform (app or website) for members to manage their schedules, book equipment, access online resources, and participate in virtual workshops. This platform can also facilitate community interaction through forums, project showcases, and collaboration tools.

Online Courses & Tutorials: To supplement in-person offerings, developing a series of online courses or video tutorials covering basic to advanced topics in STEM. These could be sold as a subscription service or bundled with membership packages.

Data-Driven Insights
Usage Analytics: Track member engagement with equipment, workshops, and events. This data can help identify trends, optimize the scheduling of resources, and personalize offers to specific customer segments. Understanding the most popular equipment or types of workshops will allow Crossroads to better allocate resources and maximize revenue.

Mental Health and Community Impact
Partner with local mental health organizations to provide resources, counseling, or support groups within the space. This will further differentiate Crossroads from traditional makerspaces and position it as a community-focused organization. Workshops or events centered on stress relief, mindfulness, or mental health awareness could also be offered. Collect data on mental health and well-being among members and determine the efficacy of such initiatives in reducing isolation and promoting creativity.

Staff and Volunteers

Safety Instructors:
Crossroads will employ at least two full-time safety instructors to ensure that all equipment is used safely and to prevent accidents. These staff members will be responsible for overseeing the safe operation of machinery and guiding members through proper usage, maintaining a secure and accident-free environment.

Instructors:
Instructors will be hired to teach in a hands-on, engaging way that encourages active participation. Crossroads will assist instructors in creating lesson plans that include physical demonstrations, allowing members to learn concepts through practical experience. Instructors will focus on showing not only the "how" but also the "why" behind each task, ensuring that participants understand the theory behind their actions while maintaining a safe learning environment.

Volunteers:
Volunteers with specific expertise in STEM fields will be crucial in supporting the community. While they will not be expected to formally instruct, their role will involve assisting drop-in members with projects, answering questions, and providing guidance. Volunteers will help create a welcoming atmosphere, especially for newcomers who may feel nervous about using the space for the first time. To further support volunteer engagement, Crossroads will reach out to students with lab or technical expertise to gain valuable volunteer experience while contributing to the community.

List of potential sponsors
Lee valley